buildings around a courtyard now exude a faded grandeur. A month ahead of Dussehra, Singh rides an elephant in a procession and inaugurates the famous Ramlila folk theatre festival of Ramnagar, begun by an ancestor in the nineteenth century. Each evening for a month, thousands come to watch a colourful play performed in the beloved Awadhi of Tulsidas's *Ramacharitmanas*.[30]

A City of Religious Pluralism

Varanasi is frequently associated with Lord Shiva and Brahminical Hinduism, but it has so much more. It has been home to many major and minor faiths, and exhibits a dynamic pluralism. Twenty-nine per cent of its people are Muslim.[31] Bhanu Shanker Mehta, a proud resident scholar, saw Kashi as the confluence of a plethora of sects, including 'the Vedics, Sanatanis, Vaishnavas, Shaivas, Shaktas, Sikhs, Nastiks, Theosophists, Christians, Muslims, Parsees, Arya Samajis, Neo-moderns of Lord Ford, and the Hippies'. 'It is the city of Yakshas, Birs, Barams, and Pirs. It has the office of all the sects like Kabirpanthis, Dadu-panthis, Niranjanis, Udasis, Raidasis, Awadhoots, Aghoris, and Tantrics,' he writes.[32] Muslims include Shia, Sunni, Sufi and Ahmadiyya. Many local and colourful folk religions still thrive, whose gods include animals, trees and rivers. *Mata*s, or mother goddesses, abound, such as Shitala, Gauri, Annapurna, Siddheshwari and sixty-four Yoginis (most appropriated by Brahminical Hinduism). Sati stones in old town are still revered. There are caste-specific gods too, like the impressively moustachioed Nishadraj—god of Nishads, or Mallahs, the boatmen and fishermen of Varanasi. Some devotees offer liquor and meat to Kal Bhairav, a fierce form of Shiva wearing a garland of skulls. Hindus visit local Sufi shrines like Chandan Shahid ka Mazar and Muslims visit Aghori ascetics seeking relief from mundane woes. Such syncretism too has been part of Varanasi's character—a fusion Hindu-Muslim culture often referred to as the Ganga-Jamuna *tehzeeb*, exemplified by Kabir himself.

Varanasi's reputation for religious pluralism is empirically well-earned too. Given the vast range and diversity of its creeds, one would expect at least some violent conflict. What's remarkable is how little there has actually been, especially through the end of the nineteenth century. For the